captives were Therāvāda Buddhist monks who converted the Burman to Buddhism.

Following the defeat of the Mon, Arawrahtā sent monks to Ceylon to bring back original texts, receiving teachers at his court, as well as embarking on an ambitious temple-building program at Bagan using Mon craftsmen and architects as well as the conquered wealth of Thaton to support the sangha. Religious scholarship flourished to the extent that monks from Ceylon began traveling to Bagan to study. Arawrahtā's successors Kyanzittha (r. ca. 1084–1112) and Alaugsithu (r. ca. 1112–1167) consolidated control over what is modern-day Myanmar and oversaw the construction of more than 2,000 temples and pagodas as well as thousands of stupas in a 25-square-mile area around Bagan. Radiocarbon dating of inscriptions found on Buddhist shrines and temples in Bagan indicate that they were built sometime between the 11th and 13th centuries CE.

Bagan would reach its cultural and artistic zenith during the early to mid-12th century. Following the reign of Alaugsithu, Bagan's power slowly waned. The kingdom at Bagan would continue to rule Burma until 1287, when it was invaded by the Mongol army following King Narathihapati's refusal to pay tribute to Kublai Khan. Even though the Mongols installed Narathihapati's son Kyawswa as a puppet ruler, the kingdom of Bagan quickly disintegrated into rival kingdoms as Arakan, Pegu, and the Mon city-states of the Moncon valley rose in rebellion against Bagan.

Following the sacking of Bagan, Lower Burma fragmented into a number of smaller city-states. Semi-autonomous kingdoms emerged at Bassein-Myaungma, Pegu, and Martaban. The Mon withdrew to the south, where they regained their independence, capturing Martaban and Pegu and reestablishing their old kingdom, Hanthawaddy Pegu (1287–1580), and controlling much of Lower Burma. In Upper Burma a series of small Shan kingdoms, Myinsaing, Pinya, and Sagaing, dominated the Ayeyarwaddy and expanded into what is now the Kachin state and along the Chindwin River. The Shan chieftain Wareru (r. ca. 1287–1306) used the power vacuum to form an alliance with Tarabya, the ambitious Mon governor of Pegu and the two of them jointly seized control of Pegu and ousted the Burmese governor, occupying much of the area south of Pyi and Toungoo. Once he was in control of Lower Burma Wareru had Tarabya executed. Wareru declared himself king, shifted his capital from Madana to Pegu, and